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Original Page: 173**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1966**Coverage Date:** 1958-1966**Place Coverage:** G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana**Section Title(S):** Social Control

Verbal duels are generally more direct (N/udukhwe had shown restraint toward his classificatory elder brother by addressing his complaint to a third party and avoiding direct confrontation) and the exchanges a good deal sharper than this. In this case the issue was clear-cut and only really involved the two men. If a valid defense or another point of view can be raised and argument does not lead to resolution, the matter draws wider and wider debate until, typically, arbitration is effected by band consensus.

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The rationale of accepting a consensus judgment is not so much in terms of whether or not the action so judged was right or justified. Acceptance is, rather, in the terms that the band found it to have been wrong and one either accepts their opinion or leaves for another band. It is acceptance of the community rather than of the conclusion that the community has reached. Punishment of offenses consists of public castigation, which ends when penitence is demonstrated by apology and the making good of any reparable damage inflicted. This is not to say that a consensus judgment is always gracefully accepted; a good deal of grouching and grumbling sometimes goes with it.

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Refusal to heed the criticism of joking partners, lack of repentance, repeated offenses, or ignoring band castigation can all lead to the offender's being "eased out" of the band. The offender is not expelled, nor even ignored and

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cut off, but is made to feel that another band 174 would be preferable to the present one. The treatment is oblique and sometimes very subtle and amounts to a public conspiracy to keep the offender (or victim?) on the wrong foot and engender the type of frustration of which he cannot legitimately complain. The offender's requests for goods or services are refused, with excuses being made for refusal. His suggestions are turned down or are so misinterpreted as to make them ridiculous. Cooperative undertakings in which he participates are bungled. Much of what he says is misheard or not heard at all. I was present on three occasions when this treatment was administered. One victim was a young man with a wife and child. They were migrants of about 10 months' standing in the band, and after settling down, the man had become progressively more obnoxious to the others by loudly and obstinately voicing his opinion on everything that was happening. His joking partners sniped away at him without result, but matters came to a head over some arrows he had borrowed without returning and his refusal to make any gifts of meat to the owner, contrary to custom. The owner protested, the band backed him up with their clear disapproval, but without result, so the band decided to ease him and his family out. After a little more than a week, the family moved to another band with no apparent resentment or hostility (they spoke of making a return visit in the future) but looking forward to more congenial company.

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